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BLINKING IN THE DARK

Robert Kennedy did not hide his frustration with Anatoly Dobrynin when he visited the Soviet ambassador late in the evening of October 23. “What would have been the point of us contacting you via the confidential channel, if, as it appears, even the Ambassador, who has, as far as we know, the full trust of his government, does not know that long-range missiles which can strike the USA, rather than defensive missiles which are capable of defending Cuba from any sort of attack on the approaches to it, have already been provided to Cuba,” Robert told Dobrynin. As it appears from his report on the meeting, he acted on the instructions of the president but told Dobrynin that he had come on his own.

Robert Kennedy “was in an obviously excited condition and his speech was rich in repetitions and digressions,” reported Dobrynin to Moscow. Kennedy listed the assurances given publicly and privately by Khrushchev and Dobrynin himself that the weapons delivered to Cuba were defensive. Kennedy went on to mention the promise that nothing would be done to